

The Loyola Index Family: Bounds, Parameter Geometry and Sensitivity Analysis

Advik Natarajan^a, Ganesh Shiwakoti^b, Michael
Arockiaraj^{a*}

^a*Department of Mathematics, Loyola College, Chennai, India*

^b*Department of Mathematics and Statistics, Florida Atlantic University,
USA*

marockiaraj@gmail.com

(Received October 3, 2026)

Abstract

The two-parameter Gutman–Milovanović family $M_{\alpha,\beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$ unifies the Zagreb, Randić, sum-connectivity and related degree-based indices. We study its normalized degree-imbalance exponential extension, the *Loyola index family*

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right),$$

with $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha,\beta}(G)$ identically.

We prove that the imbalance direction is affinely independent of the two parent directions on the degree-pair set of graphs with maximum degree at least 3, that $\log LO$ is globally convex in (α, β, γ) with gradient and Hessian given by the mean and covariance of the edge-feature vector under an induced edge measure (the standard log-sum-exp property), that the family factorises into a size coordinate and a shape (degree-ratio) coordinate, and that on the resulting ratio plane the pure- γ points separate exactly the histograms of

*Corresponding author.

edge imbalances (for algebraic $\gamma \neq 0$); we also bound the number of γ -crossings of two graphs and characterise per-graph identifiability. On molecular graphs the entire family is confined to the finite-dimensional space of edge-degree-pair counts; the pure- γ points attain this ceiling on trees up to order 12 (order 15 for $\Delta \leq 4$) and provably not beyond. In nested leave-one-out comparisons on five octane properties and a pre-registered test on the 35 nonanes, freeing γ appeared to improve prediction of the vaporization enthalpy, but this gain vanishes once the parent family is searched over a box that does not truncate it; for this property the untuned point $LO(0, 0, 1)$, essentially the irregularity index *IRLA*, matches the tuned models, and on the nonanes ridge regression on all degree-pair counts predicts better. Hence γ is presented as a structurally interpretable, parsimonious direction rather than a predictive upgrade.

1 Introduction

The literature on degree-based topological indices in chemical graph theory has grown substantially since the seminal Wiener index [53], the Randić index [46], and the Zagreb indices of Gutman and Trinajstić [28]. Among the many parametric extensions are the general Randić index R_α [8], the general sum-connectivity index χ_α [56], the forgotten index F revisited by Furtula and Gutman [16], the geometric–arithmetic index GA [51], the Albertson irregularity index [2] and the inverse σ -index problem [27].

While historical literature focused primarily on algebraic formulations to capture molecular branching and structural invariants, a distinct shift toward geometric interpretations occurred when Gutman introduced the Sombor index family [21, 22]. This formulation led to work such as establishing fundamental bounds [37] and evaluating how these new geometric invariants correlated with traditional degree-based metrics [52]. Much of this initial work concentrated on identifying extremal bounds within fundamental graph classes, particularly optimizing the general and standard variants of the index over molecular trees and related networks [1, 11, 13].

Contemporary studies have introduced modified metrics such as the mean Sombor index [36], the elliptic Sombor index [25], and the hyperbolic Sombor index [7]. Concurrently, parameters like the diminished Sombor index [39, 40] and the hybrid vertex-edge KG-Sombor index [33] have been

developed to handle unique structural constraints. Beyond purely theoretical analysis, these descriptors are increasingly integrated into practical quantitative structure-property relationship (QSPR) models and spectral evaluations. For instance, hybrid geometric-harmonic-Zagreb descriptors are now utilized to optimize the predictive analysis of polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbons [5], while modified reverse degree invariants help characterize the graph energy and entropy of complex 2D metal-organic frameworks [31]. The diversification of structural metrics is also being studied through generalized matrix methods [57], dual coindex formulations [20], simplicial network assessments [48], and finite-dimensional linear frameworks [44]; for Sombor-type variants see the recent survey [23], and for extremal results on bond-incident-degree (BID) indices in general see [3].

The natural two-parameter unification of the product-based and sum-based degree indices is the *Gutman–Milovanović family*, introduced by Gutman, Milovanović and Milovanović [26] and studied intensively in the recent bounds and QSPR literature [19, 38, 42]:

$$M_{\alpha,\beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta, \quad \alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Its special cases (most of them catalogued in [38]) include $M_{0,1} = M_1$ (first Zagreb), $M_{1,0} = M_2$ (second Zagreb), $M_{0,2} = HM$ (hyper-Zagreb [49]), $M_{-1,0} = {}^m M_2$ (modified second Zagreb), $M_{-1/2,0} = R$ (Randić), $M_{0,-1/2} = \chi$ (sum-connectivity [55]), $2M_{0,-1} = H$ (harmonic), $M_{1,-1} = ISI$ (inverse sum indeg), $2M_{1/2,-1} = GA$ (geometric-arithmetic), $\frac{1}{2}M_{-1/2,1} = AG$ (arithmetic-geometric), and the whole general Randić family $R_\alpha = M_{\alpha,0}$ [8] and general sum-connectivity family $\chi_\beta = M_{0,\beta}$ [56] as parameter axes. Parameter-optimized versions of this family and of related generalized descriptors have already been fitted to octane properties [4]. We claim no novelty for this backbone, for its reduction catalogue, or for its generic tunability: those belong to the Gutman–Milovanović literature.

In this paper we study a three-parameter extension of $M_{\alpha,\beta}$, the *Loyola index family*, obtained by attaching a separately parameterized exponential factor in the normalized degree imbalance $q_{uv} = |d_u - d_v|/(d_u +$

d_v) of each edge: $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$, so that $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha, \beta}(G)$ identically. Positive γ exponentially upweights degree-imbalanced edges, negative γ downweights them, $q_{uv} = 0$ on equal-degree edges, and on regular graphs γ has no effect. The questions this paper answers are therefore about γ alone: is the imbalance direction mathematically independent of the parent parameters, what analytic structure does it carry, and does it add measurable structural or predictive information beyond an optimized Gutman–Milovanović parent?

On the mathematical side, we prove that the answer to independence is affirmative on the admissible degree-pair set of graphs of maximum degree at least three (Proposition 2; on an individual graph γ may be absorbed by the parent parameters, Remark 1), establish global log-convexity of the family in (α, β, γ) with an exact mean/covariance interpretation of its derivatives (Theorem 3), factorise the family into size and shape coordinates and prove an exact ratio-plane theorem for the pure- γ line (Theorem 6), bound γ -crossings (Proposition 7), characterise per-graph identifiability (Proposition 8), give closed-form values on standard graph classes, and derive two-sided bounds that extend inequalities known for $M_{\alpha, \beta}$ [19, 38] to the $\gamma \neq 0$ regime. On the chemometric side we quantify the exact information ceiling of the entire vertex-degree-based class on molecular graphs, run a matched-budget nested comparison of LO against its optimized parent, and evaluate the family under the published structure-sensitivity protocol of Furtula, Gutman and Dehmer [17]; no universal ranking or predictive-superiority claim is made.

The distinguishing feature of the Loyola family within the degree-based BID class is the multiplicative $\exp(\gamma q_{uv})$ factor, where $q_{uv} = |d_u - d_v| / (d_u + d_v) \in [0, 1)$ is the normalized degree imbalance. Writing the summand as $\exp(\alpha \ln(d_u d_v) + \beta \ln(d_u + d_v) + \gamma q_{uv})$ shows that the family is a three-parameter subfamily of the exponential vertex-degree-based indices introduced by Rada [43] and studied further in extremal settings by Sığarreta [50]; general sufficient conditions for tree-extremal behaviour of such exponential edge-weight sums are known [18] (see also [10, 12]), bounds for general edge-weight functions over graphs of given order and size are given in [29], and no extremal-ordering novelty is claimed here. The pub-

lished one-parameter exponential indices (e.g. the exponential geometric–arithmetic [14] and exponential inverse symmetric division deg [15] indices) place their parameter on a single classical generator inside the exponent; the scoped contribution of this family is the multi-parameter *linear combination* in the exponent in which the two Gutman–Milovanović basis terms act as the factors $(d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$ while the imbalance coordinate carries its own parameter γ . The same imbalance ratio appears in many published indices: the diminished Sombor index, whose edge weight is $\sqrt{(1 + q_{uv}^2)/2}$ [40]; the irregularity index $IRLA(G) = 2 \sum_{uv} q_{uv}$ [47], of which the pure- γ point $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = \sum_{uv} e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$ is the exponential index in the sense of [43]; degree-ratio indices [24, 41]; and the parent family itself, since $1 - q_{uv}^2 = 4d_u d_v / (d_u + d_v)^2$ gives $M_{\alpha, -2\alpha}(G) = 4^{-\alpha} \sum_{uv} (1 - q_{uv}^2)^\alpha$ (the variable geometric–arithmetic direction). The parent family is therefore not blind to imbalance; what is new is a coordinate *linear* in q_{uv} in the exponent, which, unlike $\ln(1 - q_{uv}^2)$, is not an affine function of $\ln(d_u d_v)$ and $\ln(d_u + d_v)$ (Proposition 2). To our knowledge, and within the scope of the literature search documented in the reproducibility package, no published index couples it multiplicatively, with its own parameter, to the Gutman–Milovanović family. Since $0 \leq q_{uv} < 1$, the factor lies in $[1, e^\gamma)$ for $\gamma > 0$, equals 1 for $\gamma = 0$, and lies in $(e^\gamma, 1]$ for $\gamma < 0$; it reduces to 1 on regular graphs. The exponential form is a structural choice rather than one derived from a physical model: it lets γ act multiplicatively and only on irregularity, vanishing on regular graphs.

Also, it is useful to demonstrate the descriptor-space ceiling in which the entire family lives. On hydrogen-suppressed molecular graphs of maximum degree at most 4, every BID index is a linear functional of the ten unordered edge-degree-pair counts $m_{ij}(G) = |\{uv \in E(G) : \{d_u, d_v\} = \{i, j\}\}|$ for $1 \leq i \leq j \leq 4$; this finite-dimensional view of vertex-degree-based indices has recently been placed on a formal linear-algebraic footing by Rada [44]. Thus the Loyola family, like every BID family on this molecular class, lies inside a fixed ten-dimensional descriptor space, no matter how its three real parameters are chosen.

In sum, the contributions of this paper are: (i) the affine independence of the imbalance direction from the two Gutman–Milovanović di-

rections on the admissible degree-pair set for $\Delta \geq 3$ (Proposition 2), with an exact per-graph identifiability statement (Proposition 8); (ii) global log-convexity of the family with exact mean/covariance formulas for its parameter derivatives (Theorem 3, a specialization of the standard convexity of log-sum-exp functions); (iii) a size–shape factorisation and the ratio-plane theorem (Theorem 6), which identifies exactly what the pure- γ line can discriminate, with colliding tree pairs at every order from 13 (from 16 for $\Delta \leq 4$), and a bound of five on the γ -crossings of any two molecular graphs (Proposition 7); (iv) two-sided bounds extending parent-family inequalities to $\gamma \neq 0$ and an exact quantification of the information ceiling of the whole vertex-degree-based class on molecular graphs, including octane-isomer pairs indistinguishable by every such index (Proposition 4); and (v) a matched nested assessment, on the octanes and in a pre-registered test on the 35 nonanes, of whether γ adds out-of-sample predictive information beyond the optimized parent: an apparent gain for the vaporization enthalpy disappears once the parent is searched over a box that does not truncate it (Section 5.3); for the vaporization enthalpy the untuned point $LO(0, 0, 1)$ (essentially *IRLA*) matches the tuned models, and on the nonanes ridge regression on all degree-pair counts predicts better (Section 5.4); together with the family’s behaviour under the published structure-sensitivity protocol [17], validated against published decane-class values [7]. The family is thus offered not as a predictor superior to its parent but as an analytically transparent, parsimonious third direction on the Gutman–Milovanović parameter space.

2 Preliminaries

2.1 Notation

Let $G = (V, E)$ be a finite simple connected graph of order $n = |V|$ and size $m = |E|$. For a vertex $v \in V$, the degree $d_v = d_G(v)$ counts the edges incident to v . The maximum and minimum degrees are denoted $\Delta = \Delta(G)$ and $\delta = \delta(G)$. In the chemometric sections we work with hydrogen-suppressed molecular graphs, where the assumption $\Delta \leq 4$ holds

for alkane carbon skeletons (all graphs analysed here) and for most organic molecules, but not universally: hypervalent centres such as phosphorus in PCl_5 (degree 5) or sulfur in pentafluorosulfanyl groups (degree 6) exceed it.

The classical graph families used throughout are: the complete graph K_n , the cycle C_n , the path P_n , the star S_n , the complete bipartite graph $K_{p,q}$, the hypercube Q_k (the k -dimensional binary hypercube; 2^k vertices, $k \cdot 2^{k-1}$ edges, k -regular), the wheel W_n (an $(n-1)$ -cycle plus a universal vertex), the friendship graph F_p (p triangles sharing a common vertex), and the r -regular graphs.

For an edge $e = uv \in E(G)$ we write (d_u, d_v) for its *degree pair* understood as an unordered multiset $\{d_u, d_v\}$.

2.2 Definition

Definition 1 (Loyola index family). Let $G = (V, E)$ be a simple connected graph. For $\alpha, \beta, \gamma \in \mathbb{R}$, the *Loyola index family* is defined as,

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right) \quad (1)$$

Equation (1) is well defined for all $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{R}$ on graphs without isolated vertices (so that $d_u, d_v \geq 1$ on every edge). The expression is invariant under permutations of (u, v) because $d_u d_v = d_v d_u$, $d_u + d_v = d_v + d_u$, and $|d_u - d_v| = |d_v - d_u|$; hence $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ depends only on the multiset of unordered edge degree pairs of G . When $\gamma = 0$ the family reduces identically to the Gutman–Milovanović family [26, 38],

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0) = M_{\alpha, \beta}(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta,$$

whose classical special cases are catalogued in the Introduction. Throughout, $q_{uv} = \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$, where $\text{imb}(x, y) = |x - y|/(x + y)$, denotes the normalized degree imbalance of the edge uv ; positive γ exponentially up-weights degree-imbalanced edges, negative γ downweights them, and on regular graphs every $q_{uv} = 0$ so that γ has no effect and $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) =$

$M_{\alpha,\beta}(G)$ for all γ .

2.3 Closed-form values on standard graphs

Proposition 1. *Let $\alpha, \beta, \gamma \in \mathbb{R}$. Then:*

1. $LO(K_n; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \frac{n(n-1)}{2} 2^\beta (n-1)^{2\alpha+\beta}$ for $n \geq 2$.

2. $LO(C_n; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = n \cdot 4^{\alpha+\beta}$ for $n \geq 3$.

3. $LO(P_n; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \begin{cases} 2^\beta, & n = 2, \\ 2 \cdot 2^\alpha 3^\beta e^{\gamma/3}, & n = 3, \\ 2 \cdot 2^\alpha 3^\beta e^{\gamma/3} + (n-3) \cdot 4^{\alpha+\beta}, & n \geq 4. \end{cases}$

4. $LO(S_n; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = (n-1)(n-1)^\alpha n^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{n-2}{n}\right)$ for $n \geq 2$.

5. $LO(K_{p,q}; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = pq(pq)^\alpha (p+q)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|p-q|}{p+q}\right)$.

6. $LO(Q_k; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = k \cdot 2^{k-1} \cdot 2^\beta k^{2\alpha+\beta}$ for $k \geq 1$.

7. For $n \geq 5$, W_n has $n-1$ spoke edges with degree pair $(3, n-1)$ and $n-1$ rim edges with degree pair $(3, 3)$, so

$$LO(W_n; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = (n-1) \left[3^\alpha (n-1)^\alpha (n+2)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{n-4}{n+2}\right) + 9^\alpha 6^\beta \right].$$

8. For $p \geq 1$, F_p has $2p$ spoke edges $(2, 2p)$ and p outer edges $(2, 2)$, so

$$LO(F_p; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = p \cdot 4^{\alpha+\beta} + 2p(4p)^\alpha (2p+2)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{p-1}{p+1}\right).$$

9. For an r -regular graph G with m edges, $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = m \cdot 2^\beta r^{2\alpha+\beta}$.

Proof. Each case is obtained by enumerating the edge degree pairs of the graph and applying Definition 1. For r -regular graphs and for K_n, C_n, Q_k (all regular), every edge has $d_u = d_v = r$, so $\text{imb} = 0$ and $(d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta = r^{2\alpha} (2r)^\beta = 2^\beta r^{2\alpha+\beta}$. Items (1), (2), (6), and (9) follow immediately. For S_n all $n-1$ edges have degree pair $(1, n-1)$ with $\text{imb} = (n-2)/n$; item (4) follows. For $K_{p,q}$ all pq edges have degree pair (p, q) ; item (5) follows. For P_n ($n \geq 4$) there are exactly two pendant edges with pair

(1,2) and $n - 3$ interior edges with pair (2,2); item (3) follows by direct summation. The boundary cases $n = 2, 3$ are immediate. Items (7) and (8) are obtained by partitioning the edges of W_n and F_p into their two edge-degree-pair classes respectively and summing. ■

3 Parameter geometry and the role of the imbalance parameter

This section collects the structural results: the imbalance direction cannot be reproduced by the parent parameters on the full pair set (a short computation; almost any edge feature that is not log-linear in the degrees would pass the same test), the family has a globally convex logarithm whose derivatives have an exact probabilistic meaning, and, in Section 3.1, a size–shape factorisation with its consequences for discrimination, crossings and identifiability. Throughout, write $z_{uv} = (\ln(d_u d_v), \ln(d_u + d_v), q_{uv}) \in \mathbb{R}^3$ for the feature vector of the edge uv and $\theta = (\alpha, \beta, \gamma)$, so that $LO_G(\theta) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} e^{\theta^\top z_{uv}}$.

Proposition 2 (Affine independence of the imbalance direction). *Let $\Delta \geq 3$ and let $P_\Delta = \{(i, j) : 1 \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$ be the admissible degree pairs. Then the augmented feature vectors $(1, \ln(ij), \ln(i + j), q_{ij})$, $(i, j) \in P_\Delta$, span $\mathbb{R}^4$. Consequently, if two parameter triples θ, θ' satisfy $e^{\theta^\top z} = c e^{\theta'^\top z}$ for some constant $c > 0$ and all $(i, j) \in P_\Delta$, then $\theta = \theta'$ and $c = 1$; in particular no choice of (α', β') and scaling constant reproduces the action of $\gamma \neq 0$ on all admissible degree pairs. For $\Delta = 2$ the span has dimension 3, and for $\Delta = 1$ (the single pair (1,1), augmented vector (1, 0, $\ln 2$, 0)) it has dimension 1; in both cases the conclusion fails.*

Proof. It suffices to show that q_{ij} is not an affine function of $(\ln(ij), \ln(i + j))$ on P_Δ ; the four pairs (1,1), (2,2), (1,2), (1,3), all admissible once $\Delta \geq 3$, witness this. Suppose $q_{ij} = a + b \ln(ij) + c \ln(i + j)$ on these pairs. From (1,1) and (2,2), where $q = 0$: $a + c \ln 2 = 0$ and $a + (2b + 2c) \ln 2 = 0$, giving $a = -c \ln 2$ and $b = -c/2$. Substituting into the (1,2) and (1,3) equations gives $\frac{1}{3} = c(\ln 3 - \frac{3}{2} \ln 2)$ and $\frac{1}{2} = c(\ln 2 - \frac{1}{2} \ln 3)$; in particular $c \neq 0$. Three times the first minus twice the second gives $0 = c(4 \ln 3 -$

$\frac{13}{2} \ln 2$), hence $8 \ln 3 = 13 \ln 2$, i.e. $3^8 = 2^{13}$, which is false ($6561 \neq 8192$). Hence the augmented vectors have rank 4. If $e^{\theta^\top} z = c e^{\theta'^\top} z$ on P_Δ , then $(\theta - \theta')^\top z_{ij} = \ln c$ for all admissible pairs, i.e. $(\ln c, \theta' - \theta)$ is orthogonal to every augmented vector, so $\theta = \theta'$ and $c = 1$. For $\Delta = 2$ only the pairs $(1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 2)$ exist and a direct computation shows the augmented vectors have rank 3; for $\Delta = 1$ the single augmented vector has rank 1. $\blacksquare$

Remark 1 (Independence versus per-graph identifiability). Proposition 2 is a statement about the edge-weight *function* on the full admissible pair set, not about every individual graph: on a single graph G , the parameters are identifiable from the *function* $\theta \mapsto LO(G; \theta)$ (never from a single value of it, which is one scalar) up to the scaling noted above only when the degree pairs actually realised by G carry four affinely independent augmented feature vectors. On a regular graph nothing about θ is identifiable beyond one linear functional; on a graph whose edges realise at most three affinely independent augmented vectors, some direction of θ — possibly the γ direction — is unidentifiable from $LO(G; \cdot)$ alone. The proposition guarantees that no such degeneracy is forced on the whole molecular class $\Delta \geq 3$: the family separates parameters as a family of descriptors, even though particular graphs may not.

The next result is the standard convexity of a log-sum-exp (log-partition) function, whose gradient and Hessian are the mean and covariance of the exponent’s feature vector under the induced weights; we state it for LO because these moments have a direct interpretation here and because strictness depends on the degree pairs that G realises.

Theorem 3 (Global log-convexity). *Fix a graph G with $m \geq 1$ edges and define $F_G(\theta) = \log LO_G(\theta)$ on $\mathbb{R}^3$. Let $\mathbb{E}_\theta$ and Cov_θ denote mean and covariance under the edge probability measure $w_{uv}(\theta) = e^{\theta^\top z_{uv}} / LO_G(\theta)$. Then F_G is convex, with*

$$\nabla F_G(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_\theta[z], \quad \nabla^2 F_G(\theta) = \text{Cov}_\theta(z) \succeq 0.$$

In particular $\partial_\gamma F_G = \mathbb{E}_\theta[q] \in [0, 1)$ and $\partial_\gamma^2 F_G = \text{Var}_\theta(q) \geq 0$, so $\log LO$

is nondecreasing and convex in γ , strictly increasing in γ unless every edge of G joins vertices of equal degree. Moreover $\text{Var}_\theta(q) = 0$ at some (equivalently, every) θ if and only if q_{uv} is constant over the edges of G : this covers regular graphs ($q \equiv 0$), but also, e.g., (Δ, δ) -biregular graphs, on which every edge carries the same nonzero imbalance and $\log LO$ is affine and strictly increasing in γ . F_G is strictly convex if and only if the edge feature vectors $\{z_{uv}\}_{uv \in E}$ do not lie in a proper affine subspace of $\mathbb{R}^3$; on a regular graph $F_G(\theta) = \log m + \theta^\top z_0$ is affine and $\text{Cov}_\theta(z) = 0$.

Proof. Direct differentiation of $LO_G(\theta) = \sum_{uv} e^{\theta^\top z_{uv}}$ gives $\partial_k F_G = \sum_{uv} w_{uv} z_{uv,k} = \mathbb{E}_\theta[z_k]$ and $\partial_k \partial_l F_G = \mathbb{E}_\theta[z_k z_l] - \mathbb{E}_\theta[z_k] \mathbb{E}_\theta[z_l]$, the (k, l) -entry of $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$, which is positive semidefinite; convexity follows. The measure $w(\theta)$ has full support on E for every θ , so $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$ is singular in a direction v iff $v^\top z_{uv}$ is constant over all edges, i.e. iff the z_{uv} lie in a proper affine subspace; this proves the strictness criterion. Since $q_{uv} \in [0, 1)$, $\mathbb{E}_\theta[q] \in [0, 1)$, and $\mathbb{E}_\theta[q] = 0$ iff $q_{uv} = 0$ on every edge. On an r -regular graph all z_{uv} equal $z_0 = (2 \ln r, \ln 2r, 0)$. ■

Theorem 3 places the family in the classical exponential-family framework: moving γ reweights the edge measure toward imbalanced edges at rate $\mathbb{E}_\theta[q]$, and the Cauchy–Schwarz midpoint inequality of Section 4 is precisely midpoint log-convexity, i.e. a corollary of this theorem.

Proposition 4 (Degree-pair information ceiling). *If two graphs G and H have identical unordered edge-degree-pair count vectors, $m_{ij}(G) = m_{ij}(H)$ for all $i \leq j$, then $LO(G; \theta) = LO(H; \theta)$ for every $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^3$, and more generally $TI(G) = TI(H)$ for every vertex-degree-based index TI . Among the 18 octane isomers exactly 16 distinct count vectors occur: the pairs $\{3\text{-methylheptane}, 4\text{-methylheptane}\}$ and $\{3,4\text{-dimethylhexane}, 3\text{-ethyl-2-methylpentane}\}$ share their count vectors while differing in measured properties (Table 2), so every vertex-degree-based descriptor, tuned or not, carries a nonzero irreducible error on this benchmark.*

Proof. By Definition 1, $LO(G; \theta)$ depends on G only through the multiset of unordered edge degree pairs, i.e. through $(m_{ij}(G))_{i \leq j}$; the same holds for every vertex-degree-based index [44]. The counts for the 18 octane

isomers are computed and cross-checked in the reproducibility package; both collision pairs have their common count vectors listed in Table 2. ■

The ceiling is tight in the following sense: distinct count vectors are separated by the family at almost every parameter choice.

Proposition 5 (Generic discrimination of distinct profiles). *Fix $\Delta \geq 1$ and let $m \neq m'$ be two distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors supported on the admissible pairs P_Δ . Then $D(\theta) = \sum_{(i,j) \in P_\Delta} (m_{ij} - m'_{ij}) e^{\theta^\top z_{ij}}$ is a real-analytic function of θ that is not identically zero, and its zero set has Lebesgue measure zero in $\mathbb{R}^3$. Consequently, any two graphs with distinct count vectors are distinguished by $LO(\cdot; \theta)$ for almost every $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^3$; only graphs with identical count vectors (Proposition 4) are indistinguishable for all θ .*

Proof. The map $(i, j) \mapsto z_{ij}$ is injective on P_Δ , since $\ln(ij)$ and $\ln(i+j)$ recover the product and the sum, which determine the unordered pair. Choose $v \in \mathbb{R}^3$ such that the inner products $v^\top z_{ij}$ are pairwise distinct (this excludes finitely many hyperplanes of v 's). Along the ray $\theta = tv$, $D(tv) = \sum_k c_k e^{t\lambda_k}$ with distinct exponents λ_k and coefficients $c_k = m_{i_k j_k} - m'_{i_k j_k}$, not all zero; such an exponential sum vanishes identically only if all $c_k = 0$, so $D \not\equiv 0$ on the ray and hence on $\mathbb{R}^3$. D is a finite sum of exponentials of linear functionals, hence real-analytic on $\mathbb{R}^3$, and the zero set of a nonzero real-analytic function has Lebesgue measure zero. ■

The proof uses only the injectivity of $(i, j) \mapsto (\ln(ij), \ln(i+j))$, so the same conclusion already holds for the parent family $M_{\alpha, \beta}$ on the (α, β) -plane. Proposition 5 is therefore a property the Loyola family inherits, not an advantage conferred by γ . Likewise, since $q_{ij} = \sqrt{1 - 4ij/(i+j)^2}$ is a function of the pair, the imbalance coordinate adds no graph information beyond the edge-degree-pair counts (every vertex-degree-based index is a functional of those counts [44]); what γ adds is the new functional direction of Proposition 2, i.e. a different weighting of the same information.

3.1 Size–shape factorisation, the ratio plane, crossings and identifiability

Since $4ij/(i+j)^2 = 1 - q_{ij}^2$, every admissible pair satisfies $\ln(ij) = 2\ln(i+j) + \ln(1 - q_{ij}^2) - \ln 4$, and therefore

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = 4^{-\alpha} \sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u + d_v)^{2\alpha+\beta} (1 - q_{uv}^2)^\alpha e^{\gamma q_{uv}}. \quad (2)$$

The combination $\kappa = 2\alpha + \beta$ acts only on the edge degree sum (size), while α and γ act only on q_{uv} , which is a function of the degree ratio alone (shape). Write $n_q(G)$ for the number of edges of G with $q_{uv} = q$ (the q -histogram), and $\Pi = \{(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) : \beta = -2\alpha\}$ for the plane $\kappa = 0$, which contains every pure- γ point $(0, 0, \gamma)$ as well as $GA = 2LO(\frac{1}{2}, -1, 0)$ and $AG = \frac{1}{2}LO(-\frac{1}{2}, 1, 0)$.

Theorem 6 (Ratio plane). *Let G and H be graphs.*

- (i) *On Π , $LO(G; \alpha, -2\alpha, \gamma) = \sum_q n_q(G) ((1 - q^2)/4)^\alpha e^{\gamma q}$ depends on G only through its q -histogram. G and H agree at every point of Π if and only if $n_q(G) = n_q(H)$ for all q ; otherwise their values differ at every point of Π outside a set of measure zero.*
- (ii) *For every nonzero algebraic γ , $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = LO(H; 0, 0, \gamma)$ if and only if $n_q(G) = n_q(H)$ for all q . On any finite set of graphs the same holds for all but finitely many real γ .*
- (iii) *Let G and H be trees with distinct edge-degree-pair profiles and equal q -histograms, each having a leaf adjacent to a vertex of the same degree $d \geq 2$. Attaching a pendant path of length $L \geq 1$ at such a leaf in each produces trees with the same two properties and the same maximum degree. Consequently, for every $n \geq 13$ (and every $n \geq 16$ among trees with $\Delta \leq 4$) there are non-isomorphic trees of order n with distinct degree-pair profiles that no point of Π separates.*

Proof. (i) Setting $\beta = -2\alpha$ in (2) removes the size factor. Agreement for equal histograms is immediate. If the histograms differ, at $\alpha = 0$ the difference is $\sum_q (n_q(G) - n_q(H)) e^{\gamma q}$, an exponential sum with distinct exponents and not all coefficients zero, which is not identically zero; the

difference on Π is therefore a nonzero real-analytic function of (α, γ) , whose zero set has measure zero. (ii) For algebraic $\gamma \neq 0$ the exponents γq , $q \in \mathbb{Q}$, are distinct algebraic numbers, so by the Lindemann–Weierstrass theorem [6] the numbers $e^{\gamma q}$ are linearly independent over the algebraic numbers; the integer coefficients $n_q(G) - n_q(H)$ must all vanish. For real γ , a nonzero exponential sum with k distinct real exponents has at most $k - 1$ real zeros (Proposition 7), and a finite set of graphs gives finitely many such sums. (iii) The attachment changes the profile of each tree by the same vector, $-(1, d) + (2, d) + (L - 1)(2, 2) + (1, 2)$, so distinct profiles stay distinct, equal histograms stay equal, and the new or changed vertices have degree at most 2, so the maximum degree is unchanged when it is at least 2. The order-13 pair of Section 5.5 has a common leaf-neighbour degree $d = 3$, and the order-16 pair with $\Delta \leq 4$, $\{(1, 2)^2, (1, 4)^8, (2, 4)^2, (4, 4)^3\}$ and $\{(1, 4)^8, (2, 2)^3, (2, 4)^4\}$, has $d = 4$; this gives every larger order. ■

By exhaustive enumeration, q -histograms coincide with degree-pair profiles for all trees of order at most 12 and for trees with $\Delta \leq 4$ of order at most 15, so the pure- γ points attain the degree-pair floor exactly up to those orders and, by part (iii), at no larger order. Theorem 6 is consistent with the tie of GA , AG and the pure- γ points on the trees of order 10 (Figure 2): all lie on Π , so none can separate more than the q -histograms (that they separate all of them there is a computational fact). It also shows the limits of the pure- γ line: from order 13 generic points off Π (Proposition 5) and the Randić index (which itself leaves the floor only at order 14) separate more trees than any point of Π . In the other direction, GA , whose values are sums of square roots, merges two distinct q -histograms among trees first at order 17 (exact witness: $\{(1, 5)^{10}, (2, 2)^2, (5, 5)^2, (2, 5), (1, 2)\}$ and $\{(4, 5)^3, (1, 4)^5, (1, 5)^6, (2, 5), (1, 2)\}$ have equal GA but different q -histograms), where the pure- γ points, by part (ii), still separate all histograms. That GA depends only on the degree ratio is well known; the content here is the exact ceiling and the colliding families.

Along the γ axis the number of times two graphs can exchange order is bounded by a classical rule of signs.

Proposition 7 (γ -crossings). *Fix (α, β) and graphs G, H , and let $q_1 <$*

$\dots < q_r$ be the distinct imbalances of the degree pairs occurring in G or H . Write $D(\gamma) = LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) - LO(H; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{k=1}^r c_k e^{\gamma q_k}$ with $c_k = \sum_{q_{ij}=q_k} (m_{ij}(G) - m_{ij}(H))(ij)^\alpha (i+j)^\beta$, and let V be the number of sign changes in $(c_1, \dots, c_r)$ after zero terms are removed. If $D \not\equiv 0$, then D has at most $V \leq r - 1$ real zeros counted with multiplicity, and their number has the parity of V . In particular, for graphs with $\Delta \leq 4$, where the possible imbalances are $0, \frac{1}{7}, \frac{1}{5}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{5}$, two graphs exchange order at most five times as γ ranges over $\mathbb{R}$, for every (α, β) .

Proof. With $x = e^\gamma > 0$, D becomes the generalised polynomial $\sum_k c_k x^{q_k}$ with distinct real exponents, to which Laguerre's extension of Descartes' rule of signs applies [30]: the number of positive zeros, with multiplicity, is at most V and has its parity. The parity statement also follows from the signs of D as $\gamma \rightarrow \mp\infty$, which are those of the first and last nonzero c_k (Proposition 15). ■

The hypothesis $D \not\equiv 0$ excludes in particular graphs with equal degree-pair profiles, which are tied for every γ . The sign-change bound can be attained: two trees of order 12 with maximum degree 5 and seven distinct imbalances (bound 6) cross five times at $(\alpha, \beta) = (-1, 0)$; for $\Delta \leq 4$ the largest number of crossings we found is four, so whether five is attained there is open. The proposition concerns the γ axis only: along other directions the exponents are not the q_k and the constant five does not apply.

Finally, the per-graph identifiability noted in Remark 1 can be stated exactly. Let $R(G)$ be the set of degree pairs realised by G , $r(G)$ the number of distinct imbalances among them, and $A(G)$ the affine dimension of $\{z_{ij} : (i, j) \in R(G)\}$.

Proposition 8 (Per-graph scale-invariant directions). *(i) $A(G)$ equals the rank of the Hessian $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$ of $\log LO_G$ at every θ , and the directions v with $LO(G; \theta + tv) = e^{ct} LO(G; \theta)$ for all t and θ form a subspace of dimension $3 - A(G)$.*

(ii) $A(G) \leq \min(|R(G)| - 1, r(G), 3)$ for every graph.

(iii) If $r(G) = 2$ with imbalances $q_1 \neq q_2$, then $v = (1, -2, c)$ with $c = [\ln(1 - q_2^2) - \ln(1 - q_1^2)] / (q_1 - q_2)$ is such a direction.

Proof. (i) is the standard minimal-representation property of exponential families [9]: $\text{Cov}_\theta(z)$ has full support on $R(G)$, so its rank is the affine dimension of the support, and $v^\top z$ is constant on $R(G)$ exactly for v orthogonal to the differences of the z_{ij} . (ii) By (2), $z_{ij} = (2s + \ln(1 - q^2) - \ln 4, s, q)$ with $s = \ln(i + j)$, so pairs with the same imbalance lie on one line parallel to $(2, 1, 0)$, and r parallel lines span an affine space of dimension at most r . (iii) $v^\top z_{ij} = \ln(1 - q_{ij}^2) - \ln 4 + c q_{ij}$ takes the same value at q_1 and q_2 by the choice of c . ■

Equality holds in (ii) for every set of admissible pairs with $\Delta \leq 6$ (exhaustive check in 60-digit arithmetic), hence for all molecular graphs; it fails for some pair sets from $\Delta = 7$, e.g. $\{(1, 7), (2, 6), (3, 5), (4, 4)\}$; every failing set we found has a constant degree sum, which no connected graph realises with four distinct pairs. For example, the spider with four legs of length three realises the pairs $(2, 4)$, $(2, 2)$ and $(1, 2)$, which have only two imbalances ($\frac{1}{3}$ and 0); on it, γ is confounded with (α, β) along the direction of part (iii). For a QSPR dataset the relevant set is the union of the pairs realised by its molecules, since only a direction along which every molecule is rescaled by the same factor leaves correlations unchanged; on the octanes this union contains nine of the ten admissible pairs and its affine dimension is 3, so no parameter direction is confounded.

4 Bounds for the Loyola family

This section establishes a coherent set of upper and lower bounds on $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$. The development proceeds from a bracket bound via the edge-contribution function ψ , bounds in (m, Δ, δ) for the non-negative parameter region, a Cauchy–Schwarz interpolation bound, a uniform ratio-bound theorem, and the $\gamma \rightarrow \pm\infty$ asymptotics. The $\gamma \neq 0$ bounds rest on bounding the factor $e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$ edge by edge between 1 and $e^{\gamma(\Delta-1)/(\Delta+1)}$. Throughout, G is a simple connected graph with $\delta \leq d_v \leq \Delta$ for every $v \in V(G)$. The inequalities of Propositions 11 and 12 and of Corollary 10

and Proposition 13, the convexity part of Theorem 3, the rank-4 statement of Proposition 2 for $\Delta \geq 3$, and the order-13 profile collision of Section 5.5 have additionally been machine-checked in Lean 4 with Mathlib (graphs modelled by their multisets of edge degree pairs; equality characterizations not formalized); the formalization accompanies the reproducibility package.

Remark 2 (Attribution at $\gamma = 0$). At $\gamma = 0$ the family coincides with $M_{\alpha,\beta}$, for which inequalities of all the types developed here are already known: (Δ, δ, m) -bounds with regular/biregular equality and two-sided comparisons against M_1 , M_2 , R , χ , H , GA , AG and ISI appear in [38], and Jensen- and Hölder-type relations in [19] and further inequalities in [42]. The $\gamma = 0$ specializations of the results below are therefore not claimed as new; the content of this section is their extension to $\gamma \neq 0$, where the imbalance factor $e^{\gamma q_{uv}}$ enters every edge weight, and the tracking of how γ deforms the equality cases; the $\gamma = 0$ comparisons with the Randić, sum-connectivity and Sombor indices are not repeated here.

The summand in (1) depends only on the unordered edge degree pair (d_u, d_v) . We isolate this dependence as follows:

Definition 2. For real parameters α, β, γ and positive reals x, y ,

$$\psi(x, y; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = (xy)^\alpha (x + y)^\beta \exp\left(\gamma \frac{|x - y|}{x + y}\right). \quad (3)$$

With this notation $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$.

Proposition 9. *Let G be a simple connected graph of size $m \geq 1$ with degrees in $[\delta, \Delta]$. Then*

$$m \cdot \psi_{\min}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq m \cdot \psi_{\max}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma), \quad (4)$$

where, $\psi_{\min} = \min\{\psi(i, j; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) : \delta \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$ and $\psi_{\max} = \max\{\psi(i, j; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) : \delta \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$. The upper inequality is an equality if and only if every edge of G has a degree pair attaining $\psi_{\max}$, and the lower inequality is an equality if and only if every edge has a degree pair attaining $\psi_{\min}$.

Proof. Because G has $\delta \leq d_v \leq \Delta$ for every $v \in V(G)$, every edge $uv \in E(G)$ has its degree pair $\{d_u, d_v\}$ in the admissible set $\mathcal{P}(\delta, \Delta) := \{(i, j) \in \mathbb{Z}^2 : \delta \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$. By the definitions of $\psi_{\min}$ and $\psi_{\max}$ as the minimum and maximum of ψ over $\mathcal{P}(\delta, \Delta)$,

$$\psi_{\min}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq \psi_{\max}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma).$$

Summing each of the two per-edge inequalities over the m edges of G and using $\sum_{uv \in E(G)} \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) = LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ gives

$$m \cdot \psi_{\min}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq m \cdot \psi_{\max}(\delta, \Delta; \alpha, \beta, \gamma),$$

For the equality cases, the upper inequality $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq m \cdot \psi_{\max}$ is the sum of m per-edge inequalities $\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq \psi_{\max}$; this sum is an equality if and only if every per-edge inequality is, equivalently every edge uv has a degree pair attaining $\psi_{\max}$ over $\mathcal{P}(\delta, \Delta)$. The lower equality case is the dual. ■

Corollary 10. *Let $\alpha_1 + \alpha_2 = 2\alpha$, $\beta_1 + \beta_2 = 2\beta$, and $\gamma_1 + \gamma_2 = 2\gamma$. Then for every simple connected graph G without isolated vertices,*

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq \sqrt{LO(G; \alpha_1, \beta_1, \gamma_1) \cdot LO(G; \alpha_2, \beta_2, \gamma_2)}$$

Equality holds if and only if the ratio

$$\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha_1, \beta_1, \gamma_1) / \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha_2, \beta_2, \gamma_2)$$

is the same for every edge of G .

Proof. For each edge $e = uv \in E(G)$ and each $k \in \{1, 2\}$ write

$$\psi_e^{(k)} := \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha_k, \beta_k, \gamma_k) = (d_u d_v)^{\alpha_k} (d_u + d_v)^{\beta_k} \exp\left(\gamma_k \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right).$$

Both $\psi_e^{(1)}$ and $\psi_e^{(2)}$ are strictly positive on every edge of a graph without isolated vertices.

By the additivity of the exponents and the hypothesis $\alpha_1 + \alpha_2 = 2\alpha$,

$$\beta_1 + \beta_2 = 2\beta, \gamma_1 + \gamma_2 = 2\gamma,$$

$$\begin{aligned} \psi_e^{(1)} \psi_e^{(2)} &= (d_u d_v)^{\alpha_1 + \alpha_2} (d_u + d_v)^{\beta_1 + \beta_2} \exp\left((\gamma_1 + \gamma_2) \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right) \\ &= (d_u d_v)^{2\alpha} (d_u + d_v)^{2\beta} \exp\left(2\gamma \frac{|d_u - d_v|}{d_u + d_v}\right) \\ &= \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)^2. \end{aligned}$$

Taking square roots gives $\sqrt{\psi_e^{(1)} \psi_e^{(2)}} = \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ for every edge. Apply the Cauchy–Schwarz inequality to the positive sequences $a_e = \sqrt{\psi_e^{(1)}}$, $b_e = \sqrt{\psi_e^{(2)}}$ indexed over $E(G)$:

$$\sum_{e \in E(G)} a_e b_e \leq \sqrt{\sum_{e \in E(G)} a_e^2} \sqrt{\sum_{e \in E(G)} b_e^2}.$$

Substituting $a_e b_e = \sqrt{\psi_e^{(1)} \psi_e^{(2)}} = \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$, $\sum_e a_e^2 = \sum_e \psi_e^{(1)} = LO(G; \alpha_1, \beta_1, \gamma_1)$, and $\sum_e b_e^2 = \sum_e \psi_e^{(2)} = LO(G; \alpha_2, \beta_2, \gamma_2)$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) &= \sum_{e \in E(G)} \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \\ &\leq \sqrt{LO(G; \alpha_1, \beta_1, \gamma_1) LO(G; \alpha_2, \beta_2, \gamma_2)}, \end{aligned}$$

which is the inequality.

The Cauchy–Schwarz inequality is an equality if and only if the sequences (a_e) and (b_e) are proportional, i.e. there exists a constant $\lambda \geq 0$ such that $b_e = \lambda a_e$ for every $e \in E(G)$, equivalently $\psi_e^{(2)}/\psi_e^{(1)} = \lambda^2$ is the same constant on every edge. ■

Proposition 11. *Let G be a connected graph of size m and maximum degree Δ . For $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$ and $\gamma \geq 0$,*

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq m \cdot \Delta^{2\alpha} \cdot (2\Delta)^\beta \cdot \exp\left(\gamma \frac{\Delta - 1}{\Delta + 1}\right). \quad (5)$$

Proof. Fix an edge $uv \in E(G)$. By the definition of Δ we have $1 \leq d_u, d_v \leq \Delta$. We bound the three multiplicative factors of $\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ separately.

First factor. Because $d_u, d_v \leq \Delta$ we obtain $d_u d_v \leq \Delta^2$. Since $\alpha \geq 0$ and the map $t \mapsto t^\alpha$ is non-decreasing on $\mathbb{R}_{>0}$, $(d_u d_v)^\alpha \leq \Delta^{2\alpha}$.

Second factor. Similarly $d_u + d_v \leq 2\Delta$, and the map $t \mapsto t^\beta$ is non-decreasing for $\beta \geq 0$, so $(d_u + d_v)^\beta \leq (2\Delta)^\beta$.

Third factor. The normalised imbalance $\text{imb}(x, y) = |x - y|/(x + y)$ is maximised over the admissible set $\{(i, j) : 1 \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$ at the pair $(1, \Delta)$, where $\text{imb}(1, \Delta) = (\Delta - 1)/(\Delta + 1)$. Hence $|d_u - d_v|/(d_u + d_v) \leq (\Delta - 1)/(\Delta + 1)$ for every edge. Because $\gamma \geq 0$ and $\exp$ is non-decreasing, $\exp(\gamma |d_u - d_v|/(d_u + d_v)) \leq \exp(\gamma(\Delta - 1)/(\Delta + 1))$. Multiplying the three factor-wise bounds and summing over the m edges of G yields (5). For $\gamma > 0$ and $\Delta \geq 2$ the bound is attained if and only if $\alpha = \beta = 0$ and every edge has degree pair $(1, \Delta)$ (for connected G , $G \cong K_{1, \Delta}$); if $\alpha > 0$ or $\beta > 0$ the three factor-wise maxima are not simultaneously attainable and the inequality is strict. $\blacksquare$

Proposition 12. *Let G be a connected graph of size m and minimum degree δ . For $\alpha, \beta \geq 0$ and $\gamma \geq 0$,*

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \geq m \cdot \delta^{2\alpha} \cdot (2\delta)^\beta, \quad (6)$$

with equality if and only if G is δ -regular, except in the degenerate case $(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) = (0, 0, 0)$, where $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \equiv m$ and the bound holds with equality for every graph.

Proof. Fix an arbitrary edge $uv \in E(G)$. By the definition of $\delta = \delta(G)$ we have $d_u, d_v \geq \delta$, and we bound the three multiplicative factors of $\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ separately. Because $d_u, d_v \geq \delta$ and $\alpha \geq 0$, $(d_u d_v)^\alpha \geq \delta^{2\alpha}$; similarly $(d_u + d_v)^\beta \geq (2\delta)^\beta$; and since $\gamma \geq 0$ and the imbalance is non-negative, $\exp(\gamma |d_u - d_v|/(d_u + d_v)) \geq 1$. Multiplying the three lower bounds gives $\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \geq \delta^{2\alpha} (2\delta)^\beta$ for every edge, and summing over the m edges yields (6).

For the equality case, if $(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) = (0, 0, 0)$ then $LO(G; 0, 0, 0) = m$ and the lower bound is also m , so equality holds for every graph. Assume now that $(\alpha, \beta, \gamma) \neq (0, 0, 0)$. Equality in the summed inequality requires equality in every active per-edge factor. If $\alpha > 0$ or $\beta > 0$, this forces $d_u = d_v = \delta$ on every edge. If $\alpha = \beta = 0$ and $\gamma > 0$, equality in the

exponential factor requires $d_u = d_v$ on every edge; since G is connected, this implies that G is regular, hence δ -regular. Conversely, if G is δ -regular then every edge has degree pair (δ, δ) and equality holds. Thus, outside the degenerate case $(0, 0, 0)$, equality holds if and only if G is δ -regular. ■

The next theorem gives a single uniform template for bounding $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ both above and below in terms of any classical bond-incident-degree index whose edge contribution is strictly positive on the admissible degree pairs of the graph.

Proposition 13. *Let G be a simple graph with maximum degree at most Δ , and let $I_h(G) = \sum_{uv \in E(G)} h(d_u, d_v)$ be a BID index with edge contribution $h(i, j)$ strictly positive on every degree pair (i, j) that appears in G . Define*

$$c_{\min}^h = \min_{(i,j)} \frac{\psi(i, j; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)}{h(i, j)}, \quad c_{\max}^h = \max_{(i,j)} \frac{\psi(i, j; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)}{h(i, j)},$$

where the extrema range over the degree pairs actually appearing in G . Then

$$c_{\min}^h \cdot I_h(G) \leq LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq c_{\max}^h \cdot I_h(G), \quad (7)$$

with equality on either side if and only if every edge of G attains the corresponding extremum of ψ/h .

Proof. Fix an edge $uv \in E(G)$ and define

$$r_{uv} := \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) / h(d_u, d_v) > 0.$$

By definition $c_{\min}^h \leq r_{uv} \leq c_{\max}^h$, so multiplying by $h(d_u, d_v) > 0$ gives the per-edge bounds $c_{\min}^h h(d_u, d_v) \leq \psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ and $\psi(d_u, d_v; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) \leq c_{\max}^h h(d_u, d_v)$. Summing over $E(G)$ and using $\sum_{uv} h(d_u, d_v) = I_h(G)$ and $\sum_{uv} \psi = LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ gives (7); the equality conditions are that every edge attains the corresponding extremum of ψ/h over the appearing pairs. ■

Proposition 13 is a *sharp graph-specific* comparison: its constants depend on the degree pairs that actually appear in G . A uniform version

follows immediately by enlarging the range of the extrema.

Corollary 14 (Uniform Δ -bounded version). *With the hypotheses of Proposition 13, but with h strictly positive on all of $P_\Delta = \{(i, j) : 1 \leq i \leq j \leq \Delta\}$ and the extrema taken over P_Δ , inequality (7) holds simultaneously for every graph of maximum degree at most Δ , with constants independent of the individual graph. Equality on either side holds if and only if every edge of G realises a degree pair attaining the corresponding extremum over P_Δ ; the uniform constants are in general strictly worse than the graph-specific ones, since the extrema are taken over a superset.*

Proposition 15. *At $\gamma = 0$, $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, 0)$ coincides with the two-parameter (α, β) degree-based index $\sum_{uv \in E(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta$. Let $E_{\max}(G)$ denote the set of edges realising $\text{imb}_{\max}(G) = \max_{uv} \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$ and $E_{\min}(G)$ the set realising $\text{imb}_{\min}(G) = \min_{uv} \text{imb}(d_u, d_v)$. Then as $\gamma \rightarrow +\infty$,*

$$\frac{LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)}{e^{\gamma \text{imb}_{\max}(G)}} \longrightarrow \sum_{uv \in E_{\max}(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta,$$

and as $\gamma \rightarrow -\infty$,

$$LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) / e^{\gamma \text{imb}_{\min}(G)} \longrightarrow \sum_{uv \in E_{\min}(G)} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta.$$

Proof. At $\gamma = 0$ the exponential factor is 1 on every edge. For the asymptotics, write $\mu(G) := \text{imb}_{\max}(G)$ and $\varepsilon_{uv} := \mu(G) - \text{imb}(d_u, d_v) \geq 0$, so that $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma) / e^{\gamma \mu(G)} = \sum_{uv} (d_u d_v)^\alpha (d_u + d_v)^\beta e^{-\gamma \varepsilon_{uv}}$. For $uv \in E_{\max}(G)$, $\varepsilon_{uv} = 0$ and the summand is γ -independent; for $uv \notin E_{\max}(G)$, $\varepsilon_{uv} > 0$ and $e^{-\gamma \varepsilon_{uv}} \rightarrow 0$ as $\gamma \rightarrow +\infty$. Since $E(G)$ is finite the limit is termwise, giving the identity. The $\gamma \rightarrow -\infty$ case is dual. $\blacksquare$

5 Sensitivity analysis

We benchmark the Loyola family against the classical indices it reduces to, on three standard testbeds, following the chemometric benchmark of the

diminished Sombor study [40]: the 18 octane isomers (five NIST physico-chemical properties), the 106 non-isomorphic trees of order 10, and the 75 decane isomers. The comparison set is restricted to the exact reductions of Section 1 — $M_1, M_2, HM, {}^mM_2, R, \chi, H/2, ISI, GA, AG$ — together with the two fixed pure- γ benchmark points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ chosen for this study. No parameter in this comparison is tuned against the property data — the effect of data-driven tuning is examined separately, as an exploratory check, in Section 5.2; the edge count $m = LO(0, 0, 0)$ is omitted as it is constant on the octanes. All comparisons in this section are descriptive; given the number of properties, indices, and tuning candidates examined, no confirmatory inference is claimed. All quantities are computed in double precision and rounded *once* for display (three decimals for correlations, Q^2 and RMSE, four for structure sensitivity); tabulated gains and differences are differences of full-precision values rounded once, so they may differ by one unit in the last place from the difference of two displayed entries.

5.1 Property correlations on the octane isomers

Table 1 reports the Pearson correlation r between each index and each of the five physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers (boiling point T_B , enthalpy of formation ΔH_f , enthalpy of vaporization ΔH_{vap} , entropy S , acentric factor ω ; property data traced to the NIST WebBook [35] (each value traced to the WebBook entry listed in the provenance file), except the acentric factors, which NIST does not list and which were taken from KDB-derived compilations; the same five properties form the octane benchmark used in [40]). Units are: T_B in $^{\circ}\text{C}$; ΔH_f and ΔH_{vap} in kcal mol^{-1} (the latter at 298 K); S in $\text{cal mol}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}$; and ω dimensionless. Values for ΔH_{vap} and entropy S vary slightly across compilations; all comparisons here are made within this single, internally consistent dataset. Calculations use this author-compiled property table attributed to the NIST WebBook. All 90 molecule-level values were traced against authoritative sources (NIST WebBook first; KDB-derived compilations for the acentric factor, which NIST does not list), and classified under a strict taxonomy in which “verified” requires agreement at the value’s reported precision: 3

match exactly, 29 match a specific recorded determination at reported precision after unit conversion (gas phase confirmed for formation enthalpies and entropies), 37 agree within the audit tolerances, the source’s stated uncertainty or the span of several determinations without matching any one of them at reported precision, 13 lie within explained variation among authoritative determinations, 7 could not be verified against a reachable authoritative value (six gas-phase entropies absent from the NIST WebBook, and the 298 K vaporization enthalpy of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane: this compound is a solid at 298 K (triple point 374 K); the NIST WebBook lists standard vaporization enthalpies of 42.94 and 42.91 kJ mol⁻¹ (about 10.26 kcal mol⁻¹) together with sublimation enthalpies, whereas the benchmark value used here, 8.41 kcal mol⁻¹ (35.19 kJ mol⁻¹), is that of the standard octane benchmark compilation and matches no listed determination, so its physical reference state is unresolved; Section 5.3 reports the ΔH_{vap} analysis with this isomer excluded), and one value is a marginal conflict: the acentric factor of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane (0.247 vs. compiled 0.251); the acentric factor of 2,2,4-trimethylpentane (0.305 vs. compiled 0.303) agrees only within tolerance. Substituting the alternative compiled acentric factors changes several of the ω correlations in Table 1 at the third decimal (e.g. M_2 moves from -0.988 to -0.986) but does not change the property-wise winning descriptor or any substantive interpretation; the full sensitivity computation and the machine-readable provenance trace accompany the reproducibility package. For 3,3-dimethylhexane, 3-ethyl-3-methylpentane, 2,2,3-trimethylpentane and 2,3,3-trimethylpentane, values of ΔH_{vap} that differ from the NIST WebBook by 0.05–0.13 kcal mol⁻¹ circulate in octane benchmark tables; we use values consistent with NIST (Appendix A): two exact conversions of NIST determinations (8.97, 9.08) and two values that lie within the span or stated uncertainty of the NIST determinations and equal the API Project 44 compilation at the displayed precision (8.83, 8.90). Four entropies (*n*-octane, 2,2-dimethylhexane, 2,2,4- and 2,3,3-trimethylpentane) could not be matched to a primary source and differ from those of a widely used octane QSPR compilation by 0.15–2.29 units (the 2,3,3-trimethylpentane value coincides with that of 2,2,3-trimethylpentane); substituting the compilation values changes all twelve

S correlations in Table 1 (by up to 0.034 in $|r|$) but not the winning descriptor (HM). Apart from the four corrected vaporization enthalpies, the benchmark values are preserved as supplied for comparability.

Table 1. Pearson correlation r between the Loyola reductions, the fixed pure- γ benchmark points and the five physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers. Bold flags the best $|r|$ per column.

Index	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
$M_1 = LO(0, 1, 0)$	-0.718	-0.762	-0.935	-0.973	-0.970
$M_2 = LO(1, 0, 0)$	-0.497	-0.542	-0.811	-0.940	-0.988
$HM = LO(0, 2, 0)$	-0.654	-0.710	-0.903	-0.975	-0.982
${}^mM_2 = LO(-1, 0, 0)$	+0.855	+0.891	+0.925	+0.863	+0.794
$R = LO(-1/2, 0, 0)$	+0.819	+0.850	+0.958	+0.933	+0.898
$\chi = LO(0, -1/2, 0)$	+0.800	+0.832	+0.961	+0.949	+0.924
$H/2 = LO(0, -1, 0)$	+0.821	+0.849	+0.961	+0.933	+0.900
$ISI = LO(1, -1, 0)$	-0.005	-0.000	-0.383	-0.601	-0.738
$GA = 2 LO(1/2, -1, 0)$	+0.822	+0.858	+0.965	+0.941	+0.906
$AG = \frac{1}{2} LO(-1/2, 1, 0)$	-0.816	-0.859	-0.957	-0.939	-0.900
$LO(0, 0, 1)$	-0.828	-0.832	-0.984	-0.931	-0.929
$LO(0, 0, 2)$	-0.829	-0.846	-0.981	-0.939	-0.925

The best correlation per property is split among the reductions and the pure- γ points: the modified second Zagreb index $LO(-1, 0, 0)$ is strongest on T_B and ΔH_f , the hyper-Zagreb index $LO(0, 2, 0)$ on S , the second Zagreb index $LO(1, 0, 0)$ on ω , and the fixed pure- γ benchmark point $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on ΔH_{vap} ($|r| = 0.984$, with $LO(0, 0, 2)$ second at 0.981). At the exact-reduction triples the Loyola correlations coincide with the corresponding classical indices to floating-point precision, as they must. For each property, a descriptive post-selection paired bootstrap interval for the observed top-two $|r|$ difference ($B = 10\,000$, resampling the 18 isomers jointly, `default_rng(1)`) included zero; these intervals were not multiplicity-adjusted across the five properties and do not establish equality or equivalence. Individual bootstrap half-widths range from 0.016 to 0.096 across the headline cells (percentile bootstrap, $B = 10\,000$, `default_rng(0)`). The value of $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on ΔH_{vap} is a fixed benchmark point, not a tuned result. Recomputing each bolded correlation with single isomers deleted shifts $|r|$ by at most 0.027, indicating that no

single isomer drives the leading correlations.

Figure 1 shows the signed- r heatmap of the compared indices against the five properties.

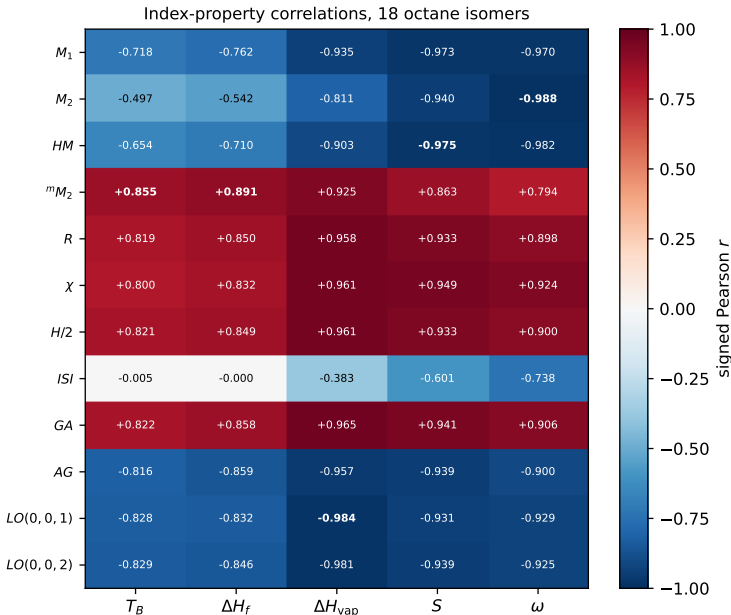


Figure 1. Signed Pearson r between the Loyola reductions, the fixed pure- γ benchmark points and the five octane physicochemical properties on the 18 isomers.

On the octanes the pure- γ points are highly collinear with the classical reductions (maximum $|r|$ with a reduction equal to 0.982 for $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and 0.993 for $LO(0, 0, 2)$).

Descriptor redundancy. The redundancy is in fact systemic, and it caps how much meaning any small $|r|$ difference in Table 1 can carry. Across the twelve compared descriptors on the 18 isomers, fourteen descriptor pairs have $|r| \geq 0.99$ (the extreme being R versus $H/2$ at $r = 0.9997$), and a principal component analysis of the standardized 18×12 descriptor matrix places 90.3% of the variance on the first component and 99.05% on the first two, with an effective rank (participation ratio of the eigenvalue

spectrum) of 1.2. The twelve-index comparison set is thus essentially a two-dimensional descriptor space, and differences in the third decimal of $|r|$ between near-collinear descriptors should not be read as meaningful rankings.

The information ceiling realised on this benchmark. Proposition 4 is not hypothetical on these data: the 18 isomers realise only 16 distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors, and the two collision pairs of Table 2 are indistinguishable by *every* vertex-degree-based index at *every* parameter choice, while their measured properties differ (by up to 1.2 °C in T_B and 1.94 units in S within the first pair, and 2.1 °C in T_B within the second). Every correlation in Table 1, and every tuned variant in the sections below, operates above this irreducible floor.

Table 2. The two degree-pair collision pairs among the 18 octane isomers. Each pair shares its complete edge-degree-pair count vector (shown as multiplicities of the unordered pairs), hence is indistinguishable by every vertex-degree-based index for all parameter values, yet differs in the measured properties.

Isomer	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
<i>shared count vector</i> 2(1, 2), 1(1, 3), 2(2, 2), 2(2, 3):					
3-methylheptane	118.9	−50.82	9.52	111.26	0.371
4-methylheptane	117.7	−50.69	9.48	109.32	0.372
<i>shared count vector</i> 2(1, 2), 2(1, 3), 2(2, 3), 1(3, 3):					
3,4-dimethylhexane	117.7	−50.91	9.32	106.59	0.340
3-ethyl-2-methylpentane	115.6	−50.48	9.21	106.06	0.330

5.2 Effect of parameter tuning near the best indices

The benchmark of Section 5.1 tunes no parameters: it compares only the exact reductions and the two fixed pure- γ benchmark points. It is nonetheless natural to ask whether small, data-driven adjustments of (α, β, γ) near the best-correlating indices could improve the fit. We probe this directly as an exploratory check. For each of the four anchors carrying the strongest column correlations in Table 1 — $M_2 = LO(1, 0, 0)$, $HM = LO(0, 2, 0)$, ${}^mM_2 = LO(-1, 0, 0)$, and the pure- γ point $LO(0, 0, 1)$ — we draw 50 random parameter triples within ± 0.3 (to two decimal places) of the an-

chor and correlate each against the five octane properties. The four pools are drawn, in the order listed, from one pseudo-random stream (NumPy `default_rng(42)`; each coordinate offset is a uniform draw on $[-0.3, 0.3]$ rounded to two decimals); the percentile bootstrap uses `default_rng(0)`. Table 3 reports, for every anchor–property cell, the anchor correlation $|r|_0$, the best of the 50 perturbations in sample $|r|_{50}$, the in-sample gain Δ_{in} , the percentile-bootstrap half-width ($B = 10\,000$), the leave-one-out correlation of the anchor LOO_0 , and a *nested* leave-one-out correlation LOO_{50} in which, within each of the four globally selected anchor pools, the best of the 50 candidates is selected using the 17 training isomers of each fold only and evaluated on the held-out one, with the resulting out-of-sample gain Δ_{out} . The anchors themselves were chosen from the complete-data correlations of Table 1, and the 18 pooled fold predictions share heavily overlapping training sets, so these values are descriptive rather than independent replications.

Table 3. Decimal parameter tuning near the four best-correlating anchors on the 18 octane isomers (50 random triples within ± 0.3 of each anchor). Columns: anchor correlation $|r|_0$; best-of-50 in sample $|r|_{50}$; in-sample gain Δ_{in} ; percentile-bootstrap half-width $\pm\text{boot}$ ($B = 10\,000$); leave-one-out correlation of the anchor LOO_0 ; foldwise nested leave-one-out correlation of the tuned family, computed within the globally selected anchor pool, LOO_{50} ; out-of-sample gain $\Delta_{\text{out}} = \text{LOO}_{50} - \text{LOO}_0$. Gains are computed from full-precision values and rounded once, so a displayed gain may differ by one unit in the last place from the difference of the displayed operands.

Property	$ r _0$	$ r _{50}$	Δ_{in}	$\pm\text{boot}$	LOO_0	LOO_{50}	Δ_{out}
<i>near</i> $M_2 = LO(1, 0, 0)$							
T_B	0.497	0.598	+0.100	0.353	0.331	0.458	+0.127
ΔH_f	0.542	0.635	+0.093	0.358	0.395	0.540	+0.145
ΔH_{vap}	0.811	0.876	+0.066	0.185	0.768	0.838	+0.071
S	0.940	0.960	+0.021	0.067	0.919	0.943	+0.024
ω	0.988	0.995	+0.007	0.018	0.985	0.985	0.000
<i>near</i> $HM = LO(0, 2, 0)$							
T_B	0.654	0.740	+0.085	0.257	0.545	0.647	+0.102
ΔH_f	0.710	0.786	+0.076	0.255	0.645	0.741	+0.097
ΔH_{vap}	0.903	0.944	+0.041	0.082	0.871	0.921	+0.049
S	0.975	0.976	+0.002	0.027	0.967	0.960	-0.007
ω	0.982	0.989	+0.007	0.025	0.979	0.982	+0.003
<i>near</i> ${}^mM_2 = LO(-1, 0, 0)$							
T_B	0.855	0.864	+0.009	0.096	0.781	0.759	-0.021
ΔH_f	0.891	0.897	+0.006	0.087	0.865	0.837	-0.028
ΔH_{vap}	0.925	0.966	+0.041	0.068	0.900	0.953	+0.053
S	0.863	0.918	+0.055	0.188	0.812	0.881	+0.069
ω	0.794	0.881	+0.088	0.246	0.730	0.853	+0.123
<i>near</i> $LO(0, 0, 1)$							
T_B	0.828	0.835	+0.007	0.161	0.771	0.764	-0.007
ΔH_f	0.832	0.842	+0.010	0.152	0.800	0.807	+0.006
ΔH_{vap}	0.984	0.985	+0.001	0.016	0.978	0.978	-0.001
S	0.931	0.948	+0.017	0.045	0.892	0.920	+0.028
ω	0.929	0.945	+0.016	0.074	0.907	0.926	+0.019

Three patterns emerge. First, every in-sample gain Δ_{in} is smaller than the corresponding single-descriptor bootstrap uncertainty scale; this comparison is descriptive and is not a formal paired or post-selection test of the gain. Second, under the foldwise nested evaluation (within the globally selected anchor pools) these descriptive point-estimate gains do not vanish — tuning near M_2 raises the out-of-sample correlation for T_B and ΔH_f by +0.13 and +0.15, and tuning near mM_2 raises ω by +0.12 — but in every such case the anchor was a *weak* descriptor for that property, and the tuned correlation only climbs part way toward the level a strong reduction already attains (tuning near M_2 lifts T_B to 0.46, whereas mM_2

already reaches 0.78). Where the anchor is already the column winner — M_2 on ω , HM on S , $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on ΔH_{vap} — the nested gain for this pool seed is -0.0003 , -0.007 and -0.001 . These near-zero values are specific to the seed: re-drawing the pools with seeds 0–99, the nested gain for M_2 on ω is small but positive in most seeds (median about $+0.003$, positive in 96% of seeds), so the defensible statement is that tuning a column winner changes its nested correlation by at most a few thousandths. Third, tuning near the pure- γ points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ does not exceed the best fixed index under nested leave-one-out on any of the five properties (Table 4). On ΔH_{vap} , where the best fixed index is the pure- γ point $LO(0, 0, 1)$ itself, the tuned value exceeds it by 0.001 in sample (0.985 vs 0.984) and falls 0.001 below it under leave-one-out (both 0.978 at three decimals; differences of full-precision values); these post-selection differences are negligible. On T_B , ΔH_f , S , and ω the best fixed reduction is higher both in and out of sample.

Table 4. Decimal tuning near the pure- γ points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ versus the best fixed index in the tested comparison set for each octane property. The best fixed index is ranked by in-sample $|r|$ (its leave-one-out value in parentheses); the decimal columns give the best over two pools of 50 random triples within ± 0.3 of $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and of $LO(0, 0, 2)$, in sample and under foldwise nested leave-one-out within the globally selected pools; the $LO(0, 0, 1)$ pool is exactly the pool of Table 3, and the $LO(0, 0, 2)$ pool is the next 50 triples of the same `default_rng(42)` stream. Indices are ranked by in-sample $|r|$ rather than LOO, as the latter is inflated by degenerate fits for near-zero-correlation indices. Tuning does not exceed the best fixed index under LOO on any property; in sample it exceeds it only on ΔH_{vap} , by 0.001, a negligible post-selection difference that does not establish superiority.

Property	best fixed	$ r _{\text{fix}}$	LOO_{fix}	$ r _{\text{dec}}$	LOO_{dec}
T_B	$^m M_2$	0.855	0.781	0.835	0.764
ΔH_f	$^m M_2$	0.891	0.865	0.850	0.815
ΔH_{vap}	$LO(0, 0, 1)$	0.984	0.978	0.985	0.978
S	HM	0.975	0.967	0.948	0.920
ω	M_2	0.988	0.985	0.945	0.926

In short, local tuning raised several nested leave-one-out point estimates for weak anchors, and except for the 0.001 in-sample ΔH_{vap} margin

noted above did not exceed the best fixed benchmark in the tested comparison set; no formal superiority claim is made. All tabled nested values correspond to positive signed prediction–observation correlations with positive predictive Q^2 , and a constant-descriptor control confirms that absolute pooled correlation alone can be inflated for degenerate descriptors (cf. the caveat in the caption of Table 4).

5.3 Does the imbalance parameter add predictive information? A matched-budget nested comparison with the parent family

The analyses above tune around fixed anchors and are descriptive. The sharper question raised by the Gutman–Milovanović framing is direct: given identical search budgets, does freeing γ improve out-of-sample prediction beyond an optimized parent $M_{\alpha,\beta}$? We answer it with a fully nested leave-one-out design. For each property and each outer fold (one isomer held out), 200 candidate parameter vectors are drawn once from $\text{Uniform}(-2, 2)$ per coordinate (triples (α, β, γ) for the Loyola model, pairs (α, β) with $\gamma = 0$ for the parent; identical budget; candidates rounded to three decimals, drawn from `NumPy default_rng(12345)` for Table 5, Loyola triples first); on the 17 training isomers only, every candidate is scored by *inner* leave-one-out root-mean-square error of the one-descriptor linear regression, the best candidate is selected, the regression is refit on all 17, and the held-out isomer is predicted. No quantity computed on the held-out isomer enters selection or fitting at any point.

The short answer is no: once the parent is searched over a box that does not truncate it, freeing γ gives no consistent gain (Table 6 at the end of this subsection). We first report the comparison in the box $(-2, 2)$, because it shows how the apparent gain arose. In that box the answer is mixed (Table 5): for the illustrative seed, freeing γ improves nested predictive performance on two of the five properties (T_B , $\Delta Q^2 = +0.136$, and ΔH_{vap} , $\Delta Q^2 = +0.086$) and degrades it on three (ΔH_f , S , ω), with the ΔH_f degradation driven by selection instability: the parent model selected the same (α, β) in all 18 folds there, while the three-parameter search selected

Table 5. Matched-budget nested leave-one-out comparison of the optimized parent $M_{\alpha,\beta}$ (GM) and the optimized Loyola family (γ free) on the five octane properties. Panel (a) is a *single illustrative candidate stream* (seed 12345, budget 200): Q^2 is the outer predictive coefficient, RMSE the outer root-mean-square error, and “LO better” counts outer folds (of 18) in which the Loyola model had the strictly smaller absolute error. Panel (b) summarizes the 100-seed sweep (seeds 0–99): median ΔQ^2 with its [minimum, maximum], and the number of seeds in which $\Delta Q^2 > 0$, at budgets $B = 200$ and $B = 500$. All selection is repeated inside every outer fold; all values are full-precision results rounded once.

<i>(a) single candidate stream: seed 12345, budget 200</i>						
Property	Q^2_{GM}	Q^2_{LO}	ΔQ^2	RMSE _{GM}	RMSE _{LO}	LO better
T_B	+0.613	+0.748	+0.136	3.700	2.983	10/18
ΔH_f	+0.855	+0.549	−0.306	0.463	0.816	4/18
ΔH_{vap}	+0.884	+0.971	+0.086	0.127	0.064	13/18
S	+0.915	+0.877	−0.038	1.310	1.573	4/18
ω	+0.979	+0.956	−0.022	0.005	0.008	5/18
<i>(b) 100 candidate streams: seeds 0–99</i>						
Property	median ΔQ^2 [min, max]			seeds with $\Delta Q^2 > 0$		
	$B = 200$		$B = 500$	$B = 200$	$B = 500$	
T_B	+0.010	[−0.524, +0.373]	+0.066	[−0.307, +0.231]	53/100	64/100
ΔH_f	−0.120	[−0.408, +0.206]	−0.095	[−0.373, +0.118]	14/100	24/100
ΔH_{vap}	+0.069	[+0.034, +0.102]	+0.068	[+0.024, +0.102]	100/100	100/100
S	−0.010	[−0.139, +0.037]	−0.011	[−0.099, +0.027]	35/100	29/100
ω	−0.010	[−0.074, +0.016]	−0.006	[−0.052, +0.012]	26/100	28/100

widely varying triples (fold-to-fold standard deviation above 1.2 in both α and β). The selected γ values are interior to the search box (maximum $|\gamma| = 0.48$), but the parent’s selections are not: for ΔH_{vap} the parent chose $(\alpha, \beta) = (1.021, -1.993)$, on the boundary of the box, in 17 of the 18 folds. The consequences of this are examined at the end of this subsection. On the one property where γ helps most stably, ΔH_{vap} , the identical triple $(-0.27, +0.27, +0.24)$ was selected in every fold. With $n = 18$ molecules these Q^2 differences carry substantial selection noise and we attach no inferential claim to them.

Because the comparison depends on a random candidate stream, the full nested design was repeated for one hundred seeds (0–99) at both budgets (200 and 500 candidates per model; 1000 configurations in all), together with a paired control in which the Loyola candidates are compared against the *same* (α, β) coordinates with γ set to zero, isolating the effect of γ from the independent candidate streams. Freeing γ improved nested predictive performance for ΔH_{vap} in every seed of this sweep (100/100 at both budgets, and 100/100 in the paired control; median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.069$ and $+0.068$, range $+0.024$ to $+0.102$) and *usually* degraded it for ΔH_f (86/100 and 76/100 seeds); T_B is close to an even split at budget 200 (53/100) but leans towards improvement at budget 500 (64/100), and S and ω usually degrade slightly. These counts describe optimizer variance over random candidate streams on one fixed set of 18 molecules; the molecules are never resampled, so the counts carry no inferential weight — in particular, 100/100 does not establish that γ improves ΔH_{vap} prediction for other molecules or data sets. The result is also sensitive to a single data cell: the ΔH_{vap} value of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane, whose physical reference state is unresolved (Section 5.1). Repeating the complete nested comparison with that isomer excluded (17 molecules, same seeds, budgets and candidate streams), freeing γ improved ΔH_{vap} in 93/100 seeds at budget 200 and 96/100 at budget 500 (paired control 95/100 and 96/100; median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.046$ and $+0.051$, range -0.048 to $+0.098$), so the gain survives the exclusion but is no longer sign-invariant.

These comparisons, however, share one design choice that turns out to be decisive: the box $(-2, 2)$. Because $\ln(ij) = 2\ln(i+j) + \ln(1-q^2) - \ln 4$

(equation (2)), the parent family reaches imbalance information through $(1 - q^2)^\alpha$ along the direction $\beta \approx -2\alpha$, but it needs large exponents to weight it strongly, and the box truncates exactly that direction. To test this, the matched comparison was repeated (this analysis was not pre-registered) with 2000 candidates per model, seeds 0–49, and boxes of half-width 2 and 12 for both models (Table 6). In the box of half-width 12 the parent’s selections are interior in more than 90% of folds for every property, and the vaporization-enthalpy gain shrinks to about zero: a hybrid control that widens only (α, β) gives median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.004$ on the octanes (28 of 50 seeds) and -0.002 on the nonanes (24 of 50), and widening all three coordinates gives -0.011 and -0.016 . On the other properties no advantage is consistent across boxes: under the hybrid control the Loyola model is ahead for octane S (38 of 50 seeds) and nonane T_B (31 of 50), but behind for octane T_B , ΔH_f and ω , and the wide box itself lowers the parent’s Q^2 for S and T_B . The vaporization-enthalpy gains reported above therefore reflect the truncated box rather than information that the parent lacks; what the third coordinate offers is economy, since an exponent near 1 approaches what the parent reaches only near $(\alpha, \beta) \approx (4.5, -9)$ ($Q^2 = 0.949$ there against 0.957 for $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on the octanes).

Table 6. Sensitivity of the matched comparison to the search box (octanes: oct., $n = 18$; nonanes: non.). Edge: share of outer folds in which the parent’s selection lies within 10% of the boundary of the box of the stated half-width. Medians of Q^2 over seeds 0–49 at 2000 candidates per model, and the number of seeds (of 50) in which LO beats GM (half-width 2) or LO_h beats GM (half-width 12). LO_h is a hybrid control with (α, β) in the wide box and γ in $(-2, 2)$, which avoids diluting the Loyola search over a wide γ range.

Set, prop.	half-width 2				half-width 12				
	Edge	GM	LO	>	Edge	GM	LO	LO_h	>
oct. T_B	69%	0.665	0.730	36	2%	0.606	0.495	0.543	21
oct. ΔH_f	52%	0.821	0.769	11	0%	0.820	0.670	0.761	10
oct. ΔH_{vap}	97%	0.887	0.957	50	3%	0.942	0.934	0.946	28
oct. S	85%	0.919	0.915	20	4%	0.858	0.848	0.882	38
oct. ω	0%	0.979	0.974	10	0%	0.979	0.938	0.951	7
non. T_B	61%	0.576	0.601	30	0%	0.524	0.392	0.577	31
non. ΔH_{vap}	93%	0.855	0.895	49	10%	0.892	0.881	0.889	24

The honest summary is therefore that tuning γ yields no consistent predictive advantage over a parent model that is allowed to reach its own optimum. Its value lies in the structural results of Section 3 and in the parsimony documented in Section 5.4.

5.4 External test on the nonane isomers and stronger baselines

Two limitations of the octane analysis are its size (18 molecules) and its restriction to index models. Both were addressed under a protocol recorded in a git commit of the reproducibility package before any nonane value was collected: the identical nested design was applied to the 35 constitutional nonane isomers, with boiling points (35 values) and standard vaporization enthalpies (34 values; none listed for 3-ethyl-4-methylhexane) taken from the NIST WebBook [35] with every value traced to its archived source page. The two properties differ in evidential status. The boiling points are NIST averages of experimental determinations (several quoted only to 1 K), so the T_B test is experimentally grounded. Of the vaporization enthalpies, only 5 of 34 are calorimetric determinations; 29 come from two compilations, the 1961 tabulation of Labauf, Greenshields and Rossini [34], which covers all 35 nonanes and 75 decanes and is not a set of individual calorimetric measurements, and a 1971 vapour-pressure handbook [54]. Because such tabulations may rest partly on structural-increment estimates, agreement with them measures consistency with the compiled values rather than independent experimental validation, and a degree-pair-based predictor may be favoured if the compiled values were themselves derived from structural increments. The pre-registered decision rule called the γ effect *replicated* if the Loyola model beat the parent in at least 80 of 100 seeds at both budgets with positive median ΔQ^2 . Four baselines were added, each fitted entirely within the outer training fold: the training-fold mean; the best of the ten classical indices of Table 1; the irregularity index *IRLA*; and ridge regression on the full edge-degree-pair count vector, with its penalty chosen by inner leave-one-out.

On the external set the pre-registered verdicts are: for ΔH_{vap} (compi-

Table 7. Nested leave-one-out Q^2 on the octanes (oct., $n = 18$) and the external nonane set (non., $n = 35$ for T_B , 34 for ΔH_{vap}). Mean: training-fold mean; Class.: best of the ten classical indices, selected inside each fold; IRLA: one-descriptor model on *IRLA*; Ridge: ridge regression on the edge-degree-pair counts; LO_1 : the fixed, untuned point $LO(0, 0, 1)$; GM, LO: median of Q^2 over seeds 0–99 at budget 200 in the box of half-width 2 (see Table 6 for wider boxes); last column: seeds in which LO beat GM at budgets 200/500. A median of differences, quoted in the text, need not equal the difference of the medians shown. All values are full-precision results rounded once.

Set, property	Mean	Class.	IRLA	Ridge	LO_1	GM	LO	LO>GM
oct. T_B	−0.121	0.593	0.585	0.344	0.591	0.662	0.652	53/64
oct. ΔH_f	−0.121	0.746	0.593	0.654	0.639	0.831	0.689	14/24
oct. ΔH_{vap}	−0.121	0.884	0.948	0.954	0.957	0.888	0.953	100/100
oct. S	−0.121	0.920	0.741	0.744	0.793	0.919	0.905	35/29
oct. ω	−0.121	0.971	0.810	0.851	0.823	0.979	0.970	26/28
non. T_B	−0.060	0.502	0.400	0.682	0.409	0.577	0.586	58/63
non. ΔH_{vap}	−0.062	0.857	0.897	0.927	0.903	0.853	0.900	95/98

lation values) the γ effect met the pre-registered optimizer-stability criterion (*replicates*: LO better than GM in 95/100 and 98/100 seeds, median $\Delta Q^2 = +0.048$ and $+0.053$), and for T_B it is *mixed* (58/100 and 63/100; unchanged in direction under the pre-registered sensitivity analysis of one disputed boiling point). The pre-registered protocol fixed the box of half-width 2, which, as Table 6 shows, binds the parent; in a box that does not, the nonane gain disappears (median $\Delta Q^2 = -0.002$ under the hybrid control). The pre-registered verdict is reported as obtained, with this deviation recorded. The pattern behind the vaporization result is the same on both sets: models whose edge weight depends on imbalance only through q^2 inside the box of half-width 2 (the classical indices, including $GA = \sum_{uv} \sqrt{1 - q_{uv}^2}$, and GM) reach $Q^2 = 0.853$ – 0.888 , while models with a term linear in q or with unrestricted counts (*IRLA*, ridge, $LO(0, 0, 1)$, LO) reach $Q^2 = 0.897$ – 0.957 . The fixed point $LO(0, 0, 1)$, which involves no tuning at all, matches or beats the tuned Loyola model on both sets (0.957 and 0.903 against medians 0.953 and 0.900), and it is the index selected in every fold for ΔH_{vap} when admitted to the fixed-index comparison. It is essentially *IRLA*: $LO(G; 0, 0, \gamma) = m + \frac{\gamma}{2} \text{IRLA}(G) + O(\gamma^2)$,

and on both sets the correlation between $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $IRLA$ is 0.996. The baselines, however, also show the limit of the claim. Ridge regression on the full degree-pair count vector predicts the nonanes better than every index model, for both properties ($Q^2 = 0.927$ for ΔH_{vap} , 0.682 for T_B); on the octanes it matches the Loyola model on ΔH_{vap} and is weaker elsewhere. This is consistent with Proposition 5 and the remark following it: the imbalance coordinate re-weights degree-pair information rather than adding to it, and its value is that one interpretable descriptor recovers most of what a model on all ten degree-pair counts achieves for the vaporization enthalpy, not that it outperforms such a model. Nor is the specific exponential form essential: the parameter-free aggregate $IRLA$ comes within 0.003 of the median Loyola model on the nonanes (0.897 against 0.900), so what matters for this property is a term linear in the imbalance, not the tuned exponential.

Finally, the nested design refits every model on the nonanes, which tests whether the *procedure* replicates, not whether an octane-trained model transfers. In an exploratory analysis (not pre-registered, and run in the box of half-width 2, so that it inherits the truncation of the parent), the parameters selected on all 18 octanes were frozen and applied to the nonanes. With the parameters frozen and only the linear calibration refitted, the Loyola model beat the parent for ΔH_{vap} in 100/100 seeds at both budgets (median $Q^2 = 0.910$ and 0.916 against 0.864 and 0.865) and for T_B in 65/100 and 82/100. With the octane calibration frozen as well, both models extrapolate poorly from C_8 to C_9 and the Loyola model is worse than the parent (median Q^2 between -2.22 and -0.72 for LO against 0.06 to 0.44 for GM). Because both comparisons inherit the truncated box, they do not bear on whether γ adds predictive information.

The seed counts above measure optimizer variance only. To indicate molecule-level uncertainty we also computed, post hoc, a paired bootstrap over molecules (2000 resamples) of the median-over-seeds ΔQ^2 , conditional on the fitted outer predictions (selection is not repeated within resamples, so the intervals do not account for uncertainty from refitting and model selection). The 95% intervals for LO minus GM on ΔH_{vap} are $[+0.014, +0.111]$ on the octanes but $[-0.006, +0.113]$ on the nonanes

at budget 200 ($[-0.005, +0.119]$ at 500): the external gain met the pre-registered criterion, yet its interval narrowly includes zero. The interval for LO minus ridge on the nonanes, $[-0.101, +0.032]$, includes zero as well, and the T_B intervals are wide ($[-0.212, +0.222]$ for LO minus GM on the nonanes). The one octane interval that excludes zero in the other direction is that for ΔH_f , where freeing γ is worse ($[-0.281, -0.044]$). All these intervals refer to the box of half-width 2. Given Table 6, no γ effect remains to be established; the intervals are reported for completeness.

5.5 Degeneracy across tree orders

Degeneracy measures an index’s ability to discriminate non-isomorphic graphs [32]; lower is better. On the 106 non-isomorphic trees of order 10 we use the distinct-value convention

$$\text{Degeneracy}(\%) = 100 \left(1 - \frac{k}{N} \right), \quad k = \#\{\text{distinct index values}\}, \quad N = 106,$$

i.e. the number $N - k$ of structures in excess of the distinct values, as a percentage of N (this is not the share of structures lacking a unique value, which is larger: for $LO(0, 0, 1)$ on this set 45 of the 106 trees, 42.5%, share their value with another tree). The pure- γ points $LO(0, 0, 1)$ and $LO(0, 0, 2)$ attain degeneracy 25.5% (79 distinct values), among the lowest of all compared indices and tied with R , GA , and AG ; indeed the 106 trees realise only 79 distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors, so 25.5% is the minimum degeneracy attainable by *any* degree-pair-based index on this set, and the pure- γ points attain this floor; the reason, and the order at which this stops, are given by Theorem 6; the first Zagreb index $LO(0, 1, 0)$ (83.0%) and the second Zagreb index $LO(1, 0, 0)$ (67.0%) are the most degenerate (Figure 2).

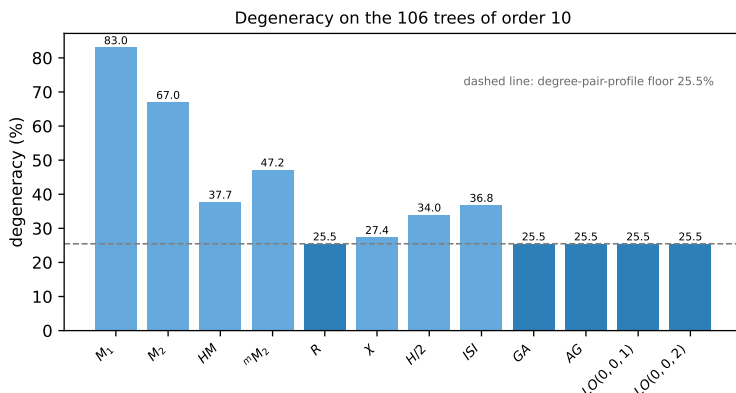


Figure 2. Degeneracy percentage of the compared indices on the 106 non-isomorphic trees of order 10. The dashed line marks the degree-pair-profile floor, $25.5\% = 100(1 - 79/106)$: the 106 trees realise only 79 distinct edge-degree-pair count vectors, so no vertex-degree-based index can fall below it.

To test whether this floor attainment is peculiar to order 10, the same computation was repeated for all non-isomorphic trees of orders 7 through 12 and, separately, for the molecular subsets with $\Delta \leq 4$ (Table 8). The pure- γ points attain the degree-pair-profile floor at *every* order in both sets. Honesty requires noting that the Randić index also attains the floor at every order in this range (while χ falls off the floor from order 10), so floor attainment distinguishes the pure- γ points from the most degenerate classical indices (M_1 , M_2) but not from R ; the observation is that the imbalance weights lose nothing, not that they are unique in this respect. Theorem 6 turns this into an exact statement: the pure- γ points separate precisely the q -histograms, which coincide with the degree-pair profiles up to order 12 (order 15 for $\Delta \leq 4$) and not beyond. Among the trees of order 13 the profiles $\{(1, 2)^1, (1, 3)^2, (1, 6)^5, (2, 3)^2, (2, 6)^1, (3, 3)^1\}$ and $\{(1, 3)^3, (1, 6)^5, (2, 2)^1, (2, 3)^2, (3, 6)^1\}$ (exponents are edge multiplicities) share the q -histogram $\{0^1, \frac{1}{5}^2, \frac{1}{3}^1, \frac{1}{2}^3, \frac{5}{7}^5\}$, and the pure- γ points realise 566 distinct values against 570 profiles; among molecular trees ($\Delta \leq 4$) the first failure occurs at order 16 (809 values against 810 profiles). The Randić index still attains the floor at order 13 (570 values) and falls below

it at order 14 (1095 values against 1100 profiles, where the pure- γ points give 1090).

Table 8. Discrimination across tree orders $n = 7$ –12: number of trees N , number of distinct edge-degree-pair profiles (the floor attainable by any vertex-degree-based index), and distinct-value counts for representative indices. “mol.” denotes the molecular subset $\Delta \leq 4$.

n	set	N	floor	M_1	M_2	R	$LO(0, 0, 1)$	$LO(0, 0, 2)$
7	all	11	11	7	9	11	11	11
7	mol.	9	9	5	7	9	9	9
8	all	23	21	9	17	21	21	21
8	mol.	18	16	6	13	16	16	16
9	all	47	40	13	22	40	40	40
9	mol.	35	28	7	16	28	28	28
10	all	106	79	18	35	79	79	79
10	mol.	75	49	8	21	49	49	49
11	all	235	152	21	43	152	152	152
11	mol.	159	83	9	25	83	83	83
12	all	551	294	27	57	294	294	294
12	mol.	355	137	10	28	137	137	137

5.6 Structure sensitivity on decane isomers

The structure-sensitivity criterion for descriptor quality was introduced by Furtula, Gutman and Dehmer [17], with a fingerprint-based variant due to Rakić and Furtula [45]. We implement the published protocol on the 75 decane isomer trees Ψ : for each tree G , the similar-structure set $S(G) \subset \Psi$ consists of the non-isomorphic trees obtainable from G by relocating a single edge within the molecular class (graph edit distance two, $\Delta \leq 4$ preserved); then

$$SS(TI, G) = \frac{1}{|S(G)|} \sum_{\Omega \in S(G)} \frac{|TI(\Omega) - TI(G)|}{TI(G)},$$

$$Abr(TI, G) = \max_{\Omega \in S(G)} \frac{|TI(\Omega) - TI(G)|}{TI(G)},$$

and the class-level $SS(TI)$ and $Abr(TI)$ are the means over all 75 trees. On this class every $S(G)$ is nonempty (sizes 7 to 43), the neighbour re-

lation is symmetric, and $Abr \geq SS$ holds throughout, as it must. As an external control, the implementation reproduces the published decane-class values of Barman and Das [7] for the seven indices common to both studies (M_1 , mM_2 , R , χ , H , GA , AG ; fourteen tabulated SS/Abr values): eleven agree exactly at the four displayed decimals and the remaining three differ by one unit in the fourth decimal (the cell-by-cell comparison is in the file `fgd_published_control.csv` of the reproducibility package; our values for all twelve compared indices are in Table 9). Under the published desideratum (SS large, Abr small [17]), the pure- γ point $LO(0, 0, 2)$ has a structure sensitivity equal to that of the hyper-Zagreb index (0.1257 against 0.1256) at a markedly smaller abruptness (0.274 against 0.313), and the sensitivity-to-abruptness ratios of the pure- γ points (0.4579 and 0.4565) are comparable to those of $H/2$, GA and R (0.448–0.451); in view of the redundancy analysis of Section 5.1, these third-decimal differences are not a ranking. Two qualifications limit this. First, SS is not a fixed property of the family: along the pure- γ line it grows with γ (0.031, 0.062, 0.126, 0.319 at $\gamma = 0.5, 1, 2, 5$) while the ratio peaks near $\gamma = 2$ and then falls (0.427 at $\gamma = 5$). Second, the parameter-free aggregate $IRLA$, which the pure- γ points approximate to first order in γ , has a higher ratio ($SS = 0.2343$, $Abr = 0.5066$, ratio 0.4625). The favourable sensitivity–abruptness balance is therefore a property of linear imbalance weighting rather than of the tuned exponential, and the SS margin over hyper-Zagreb is a tie, not a ranking.

Table 9. Structure sensitivity SS , abruptness Abr , and their ratio on the 75 decane isomers under the published similar-structure protocol of [17] (single-edge relocation within the molecular class).

Index	SS	Abr	SS/Abr
M_1	0.0566	0.1336	0.4238
M_2	0.0922	0.2443	0.3776
HM	0.1256	0.3126	0.4017
mM_2	0.0516	0.1177	0.4384
R	0.0264	0.0588	0.4481
χ	0.0264	0.0591	0.4463
$H/2$	0.0516	0.1143	0.4514
ISI	0.0226	0.0597	0.3795
GA	0.0241	0.0535	0.4507
AG	0.0256	0.0579	0.4415
$LO(0, 0, 1)$	0.0624	0.1367	0.4565
$LO(0, 0, 2)$	0.1257	0.2745	0.4579

6 Conclusion and further directions

The Loyola family is the normalized degree-imbalance exponential extension of the Gutman–Milovanović family $M_{\alpha,\beta}$ [26, 38], to which it reduces identically at $\gamma = 0$. What the third parameter contributes is now stated precisely: the imbalance direction is affinely independent of the two parent directions on the admissible degree-pair set for $\Delta \geq 3$ (Proposition 2; a class-level statement, see Remark 1); the family has a globally convex logarithm whose γ -derivatives are the mean and variance of the edge imbalance under an induced edge measure (Theorem 3); and the two-sided bounds of Section 4 extend inequalities known for the parent to the $\gamma \neq 0$ regime. The size–shape factorisation and the ratio-plane theorem (Theorem 6) identify exactly what the pure- γ line can discriminate, namely the histogram of edge imbalances, and show that it loses degree-pair information from tree order 13 (order 16 for $\Delta \leq 4$); two molecular graphs exchange order at most five times along the γ axis (Proposition 7); and per-graph identifiability is governed by the number of distinct imbalances a graph realises (Proposition 8). The generic discrimination of distinct degree-pair profiles (Proposition 5) is inherited from the parent rather

than created by γ , and the imbalance coordinate re-weights the degree-pair information without adding to it.

Chemometrically the conclusions are deliberately honest. Every vertex-degree-based index on the octane benchmark operates above an irreducible floor set by two degree-pair collision pairs (Proposition 4); the twelve-index comparison set is effectively two-dimensional, so third-decimal correlation differences carry no ranking information; and the apparent vaporization-enthalpy gain from freeing γ , seen in every seed of the octane sweep and meeting the pre-registered criterion on the 35 nonanes (mostly compilation values), disappears once the parent family is searched over a box that does not truncate it (Table 6). Tuning γ therefore yields no predictive advantage over the parent; the untuned point $LO(0, 0, 1)$, essentially the irregularity index $IRLA$, matches the tuned models, and ridge regression on the full degree-pair counts predicts the nonanes better than every index model (Section 5.4). The imbalance coordinate is a parsimonious, interpretable summary of degree-pair information, approaching with an exponent near 1 what the parent reaches only at large exponents (a property shared with $IRLA$, of which $LO(0, 0, \gamma)$ is the exponential version), not a better predictor than a model that uses all of it. Under the published structure-sensitivity protocol, $LO(0, 0, 2)$ matches the hyper-Zagreb sensitivity at smaller abruptness, but sensitivity is a tunable function of γ and the parameter-free $IRLA$ has a slightly better sensitivity-to-abruptness balance. The Loyola family is hence best viewed as an analytically transparent third direction on the Gutman–Milovanović parameter space, with an exact description of what that direction can and cannot resolve, confined — like every vertex-degree-based family — to the finite-dimensional degree-pair descriptor space on molecular graphs.

Building on the Loyola index, the following open problems indicate natural directions for further work:

1. Sharp two-sided bounds for $LO(G; \alpha, \beta, \gamma)$ via degree-based indices lying outside the family, such as the atom-bond-connectivity index ABC and the Sombor index.
2. Extremal-graph characterisations (not attempted in this paper) for several graph classes, including trees, unicyclic and bicyclic graphs.

3. Chemometric extension to additional chemical compound classes such as benzene derivatives, alkane homologues beyond the octanes, nonanes and decanes studied here and to compound-class-specific QSPR endpoints.

Acknowledgment: The authors thank colleagues for helpful discussions.

A Octane isomer property data

For reproducibility, Table 10 lists the full 18-isomer dataset used in Section 5. Units: T_B in $^{\circ}\text{C}$; ΔH_f and ΔH_{vap} in kcal mol^{-1} (ΔH_{vap} at 298 K); S in $\text{cal mol}^{-1}\text{K}^{-1}$; ω dimensionless. The ΔH_{vap} values of 3,3-dimethylhexane (8.97), 3-ethyl-3-methylpentane (9.08), 2,2,3-trimethylpentane (8.83) and 2,3,3-trimethylpentane (8.90) are values consistent with the NIST WebBook determinations (see Section 5.1 for the exact-versus-within-uncertainty status of each). The ΔH_{vap} entry of 2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane is a benchmark-compilation value whose physical reference state is unresolved (Section 5.1).

Table 10. Physicochemical properties of the 18 octane isomers.

Isomer	T_B	ΔH_f	ΔH_{vap}	S	ω
<i>n</i> -octane	125.6	−49.82	9.92	111.55	0.398
2-methylheptane	117.6	−51.50	9.48	109.84	0.378
3-methylheptane	118.9	−50.82	9.52	111.26	0.371
4-methylheptane	117.7	−50.69	9.48	109.32	0.372
2,2-dimethylhexane	106.8	−53.71	8.92	103.13	0.339
2,3-dimethylhexane	115.6	−51.13	9.27	108.02	0.348
2,4-dimethylhexane	109.4	−52.44	9.03	106.98	0.344
2,5-dimethylhexane	109.1	−53.21	9.05	105.72	0.357
3,3-dimethylhexane	111.9	−52.61	8.97	104.74	0.322
3,4-dimethylhexane	117.7	−50.91	9.32	106.59	0.340
3-ethyl-2-methylpentane	115.6	−50.48	9.21	106.06	0.330
3-ethyl-3-methylpentane	118.3	−51.38	9.08	101.48	0.302
3-ethylhexane	118.5	−50.40	9.48	109.43	0.362
2,2,3-trimethylpentane	109.8	−52.61	8.83	101.31	0.300
2,2,4-trimethylpentane	99.2	−53.57	8.40	101.81	0.305
2,3,3-trimethylpentane	114.8	−51.73	8.90	101.31	0.291
2,3,4-trimethylpentane	113.5	−51.97	9.01	102.39	0.317
2,2,3,3-tetramethylbutane	106.5	−53.99	8.41	93.06	0.247

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